

isn't half bad though, ditto the menu buttons. It also feels very solid in-hand.

Samsung's SCH F309 is a CDMA phone and a decently built one at that. The body feels solid but the keypad isn't the best we've seen and for its price, we did expect more. LG's RD 6600 sports a metallic mirror finish, and is the costliest of the CDMA phones in this comparison. It's a nice looking phone and has a very decent screen. We also liked the number keypad which although a little cramped, works fine. The menu buttons are good, although we feel Sony Ericsson designed their menu buttons on the W350 better.

Samsung's M200 is a large, bulky looking phone and its inferior build quality aside could be mistaken for the L700. But that's not meant in a derogatory sense at all, as the L700 is unusually well built. The keypad on the M200 is nearly the same in terms of layout as compared to the L700 but its feedback is not as good.

Performance

In the signal quality tests we had a bit of a mixed bag. Firstly, the LG KM380T and Samsung L700 were the clearest phones in Zone 1. In Zone 2, which is a more difficult zone to perform well in — being deep inside our building and in an area that kills most service provider signals — the Samsung M200 did better than its costlier sibling by a small margin. Hands-free quality on the L700 was still the best though; with the KM380T losing to a few other phones as well. The Sony Ericsson also has a good hands-free unit, but then Walkman phones are known for their good headsets. Samsung also has the most prolific camera amongst



Joint Winners:
LG KP220 and
Samsung M200



the lot; it's got a better specification (2 megapixels) and also performs the best. It's surprising then that this phone doesn't have the best video quality — the cheaper Sony Ericsson Z555 gets that distinction. Both the Sony Ericsson W350 and the Samsung L700 have the best music quality and these are the phones to look at if you want something that doubles as a decent MP3 player. The same two phones also give the best video playback performance and it's safe to call them the best overall multimedia phones of the bunch. Samsung's L700 is the costliest phone of this bunch at Rs. 7,800 and is also the best performing phone overall, proving that money and performance do, indeed have a directly proportionate relationship.

And The Winner Is

For our Digit Best Buy we have a tie in this category. The joint winners are the LG KP220 and the Samsung M200. The M200 is a bit better than the KP 220 in terms of overall features, comfort and performance but this margin is small. Moreover

the M200 is also a little costlier. Both these phones will do very nicely for someone looking at a phone that has a camera and memory expansion, and for audio and video playback. If you want something a little more upmarket then look at either of the Samsung L700, LG KM380T and the Sony Ericsson W350. We prefer the latter two because they are more attractive and have a fancy flap design; although the L700 is the better built phone. Amongst the CDMA phones, LG's RD 6600 is the best option and it's much cheaper than the Samsung SCH F309. LG's KP220 is also a good option for someone looking for a reasonably feature rich phone that

is also superb value for money.

To sum it up

We did something a little different this time, and also took a look at CDMA handsets. Unlike GSM handsets, which one purchases for the device alone, CDMA handsets are typically part of a service provider's package. Therefore, the actual quality of service offered also plays a large part while picking up a CDMA device. For example, Reliance could offer a particular handset with only a select bunch of service plans thereby giving consumers the binary options of taking it, or leaving it. That being said it's good to see some decent GSM handsets also available at shoestring budgets, although GSM handsets are still costlier than their CDMA counterparts, and will probably always be so. It was also refreshing to find some true jewels in the rough, as the phrase goes. We will be taking a more comprehensive look at the more drool-worthy handsets of 2009. But that's another story, for another month. ■

michael.browne@thinkdigit.com



A 1 TB drive,
 DVD-sets, books,
 full-version
 software,
 and even an
**all expense
 paid trip**
 to our office,
 up for grabs.

Page 78
 for details...